

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science

Lecture 1 (Teaching Week 2): Is this politics?

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Is *this* politics?

POU11011 — Introduction to Political Science

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — full-bleed opening montage, five images in a 2-row grid (see the commented `.absolute` layout above for placement): a “for rent” sign with a red slash, a heated dinner table, a hospital/union picket line, a phone mid-scroll, a tank outside a parliament building. No captions yet — let the room guess before you tell them what each one is.

Case 1: the rent freeze

A government caps how much a landlord can raise the rent. A landlord says it's confiscation and stops maintaining the property. A tenant says it's the only thing standing between her and homelessness. Neither of them is lying.

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — photo of a “To Let” sign, or an Irish rent-pressure-zone news clip. Noah: swap in whatever the live rental-market story is in September 2026 — this one ages fast.

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Revision log, 2026-09-03

- Replaced “One thing we’re *not* doing today” with “Politics vs political *science*” — positive claim slide, pitch moved to printnote
- “What do all five have in common?” — dropped `.smaller`, added `.breathe` for vertical space
- “Reading for next time” — added parting line for Thursday
- Density: 45.0 → 45.0 w/slide (unchanged)

Content pass, 2026-09-03 (second)

- “Six questions we’ll spend the term on” was a wall of six bold numbered questions — split into two slides of three (“Three questions before study week” / “And three after it”) and rewritten shorter and blunter. The veto-player printnote moved to the second slide.
- Poll slot: actual question text written (below); tool still Noah’s call.

Case 2: the family row

Sunday dinner at home. Someone brings up the Occupied Territories Bill — should Ireland ban trade with illegal settlements? One cousin thinks it's basic decency. Another thinks it's virtue-signalling that will cost jobs. Nobody's vote is being counted. Nobody's a politician. Voices are raised anyway.

PLACEHOLDER

Noah: currency check needed before delivery — confirm in September 2026 whether the Occupied Territories Bill has passed, stalled, or been amended since this was drafted (mid-2026). If the news has moved on, swap in whatever the live “kitchen-table foreign policy row” is that week — Ireland's neutrality debate is a reliable backup.

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — a Sunday-dinner-table photo (generic stock, not staged as this specific family), or a shot of the Dáil chamber mid-debate, to signal “the same argument, but in the room where it's supposed to happen.” Use as an inline `.absolute` image, not full-bleed — this slide should stay text-forward.

Case 3: the nurses' strike

Nurses walk out. Patients' appointments get cancelled. The union says pay hasn't kept pace with the cost of living. The HSE says there's no more money to give. Someone, eventually, has to decide who bends.

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — photo of an INMO picket line or similar. Noah: your call whether to use a real recent Irish nurses'/teachers' dispute or keep this generic.

Case 4: the viral post

Someone posts something. It gets four million views by lunchtime. A politician is forced to respond. A policy that wasn't on anyone's radar yesterday is on the evening news tonight.

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — screenshot-style graphic of a generic viral post (blurred/fake handle — don't use a real person's actual post without checking it's still the live example you want in September). Noah: pick something current closer to the time.

Case 5: the coup

Soldiers surround a parliament building. The president is placed under house arrest. State television starts playing military marches. By morning there's a new government and nobody voted for it.

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — photo of soldiers/tanks outside a government building. Noah: pick a real, current example close to delivery — there is depressingly rarely a shortage of these.

Quick poll: which of these is politics?

PLACEHOLDER

LIVE POLL — tool still Noah's call. **TCDpolls (Vevox)** is already licensed by Trinity as a Blackboard tool, so it is the cheap default; pick one before Week 1 and standardise it for the term.

Question, ready to wire up — multiple choice, select all that apply:

Which of these five is politics? 1. *The rent freeze* 2. *The family row* 3. *The nurses' strike* 4. *The viral post* 5. *The coup*

Expect a big spread on 2 and 4, near-unanimous yes on 5, and an argument about 1 and 3. The spread is the finding — use it.

What do all five have in common?

- Somebody wants something somebody else doesn't want to give.
- There isn't enough of it to go around — money, respect, land, power, the right to be listened to.
- Eventually, *some* outcome happens. A decision gets made, even if that decision is “nothing changes.”

That's it. That's the core of politics: **conflict, plus collective decision-making, under scarcity.**

A working definition

Politics: *the process by which people decide, collectively, how to handle the things they disagree about — who gets what, who's bound by the outcome, and whether that outcome sticks.*

Notice what's *not* in that definition: parliaments, elections, politicians. Those are one place politics happens. They are not the only place.

Four ways people have defined it

Political scientists have argued about this for a while. Roughly:

- **The art of government** — what happens in cabinet rooms and parliaments. (Narrow.)
- **Public affairs** — anything in the public sphere, stops at the front door.
- **Compromise and consensus** — *a method*: settling disagreement by negotiation rather than force. (Crick's view — next slide.)
- **Power** — anywhere one person or group gets another to do something they wouldn't otherwise do. (Broadest.)

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — this is the flattest, most taxonomy-shaped slide in the deck; it needs a visual more than any other slide does. Simplest fix: a 2x2 grid of small photos behind or beside the four bullets — a cabinet-room table, a newspaper front page, a handshake across a negotiating table, a boss talking to an employee — one per definition, unlabelled. Use as [.absolute](#) images, not full-bleed.

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This compresses what used to be a four-slide march in the prior version of this course (and in Heywood himself) into one slide, per the plan — the taxonomy is background, not the lecture. If you want to spend real time on any one of these, “power” is the one that pays off directly: it's the whole of Lecture 2.

Why bother defining it at all?

Because how you draw the line decides what counts as a *political* problem — and what gets waved away as “just personal,” “just private,” “just the market.”

Bernard Crick's defence

“Politics [is] the activity by which differing interests within a given unit of rule are conciliated by giving them a share of power in proportion to their importance to the welfare and the survival of the whole community.”

— Bernard Crick, *In Defence of Politics* (1962)

Crick's real point isn't the definition. It's the *defence*: politics — messy, slow, compromising — beats the alternatives.

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — small portrait of Bernard Crick, or a cover shot of *In Defence of Politics*, placed `.absolute` in a bottom corner so it doesn't compete with the quote. Both are easy to find on Wikimedia Commons or the publisher's page.

The payoff

- Politics is not the noise that gets in the way of solving problems.
- Politics **is** how societies solve problems they can't solve by force or by unanimous agreement — which is most problems.
- Every case today was politics working (or straining, or breaking). None of them were an aberration.

That's the argument this whole module is built on. Everything from here is “so — how does that actually work?”

So what's this module actually about?

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — full-bleed divider background. This is the biggest “turn the page” moment in the lecture after the cold open — give it a real photo, not flat colour. Something that reads as “the whole world of politics”: a wide shot of a national parliament chamber in session, or a busy protest/election-day street scene. Use as `# So what's this module actually about? {background-image="w02-lec01-img/world-politics.jpg"}`.

Three questions before study week

1. **Where do states come from — and why can some of them actually run a country while others can't?**
2. **What are people on the left and the right actually arguing about?**
3. **Why do a few identities become battle lines, and most never do?**

And three after it

4. **Democracy or dictatorship — and would you notice the moment one turned into the other?**
5. **Who can stop whom?** Constitutions, parliaments, planning objectors: who actually holds a veto?
6. **How do we know any of this is true** — and how do political scientists get fooled?

Same toolkit, twenty different rooms.

Politics vs political science

Not opinion, not punditry: **systematic comparison, evidence over anecdote, “how would you know that?” asked out loud** — starting properly in Lecture 3, every few weeks from there.

By Lecture 20 we turn the toolkit on itself: how political scientists get fooled, and how they try not to be. **Hold onto your answer from today** — we’ll ask whether it survives.

TODO

Noah: your own line here on why “science” and not “studies” — this is your call to make out loud, not mine to fabricate. (Comparative method? Falsifiability? Just “because we test things”?) One sentence is plenty.

Who am I?

- From Minneapolis, Minnesota.
- Lived in New York, Abu Dhabi, and Moscow before Dublin.
- My own research: Russian politics, authoritarianism, corruption — when and why mayors get arrested, why some autocracies are more corrupt than others, how ordinary people decide whether to protest.

PLACEHOLDER

IMAGE — small photo strip or pin-map of Minneapolis / New York / Abu Dhabi / Moscow / Dublin, placed `.absolute` down one side of the slide. A real personal photo from one of those cities beats a generic map if Noah has one to hand.

TODO

Noah: personalise this. Your Comparative Politics version of this slide has more specific research questions (rally-round-the-flag effects, protest attitudes) — decide whether first-years get the same level of detail or a lighter version. This is also a natural slot for one concrete anecdote (a Moscow story, a “why I ended up studying this” story) if you want to open with something more personal than a bullet list.

How this module runs

- Two 50-minute lectures a week, ten teaching weeks (twenty slots total) — this is one of them.
- Four tutorials across the term, led by TAs — not weekly, and not mini-lectures. They're where you argue about the cases.
- Readings: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, 6th edition (2025).

PLACEHOLDER

Lecture days, times, and rooms — TBD, department scheduling not finalised. Same for tutorial sign-up mechanics and TA names/emails.

How you're assessed

- **10% — tutorial discussion points.** Three short written submissions across the four tutorial sessions, plus attendance and participation.
- **30% — a short assignment.** An 800-word blog post applying a course concept to a live political event.
- **60% — a final essay.** 1,500 words, end of term, your choice from a set of questions.

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Weights and formats pulled straight from `_course.yml`'s `assessment:` block (10/30/60, matching the filed module outline — NOT the 2025-26 preview, which was 10/25/65). Due dates are still TBD there too; don't invent one for this slide.

Reading for next time

Read: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, Chapter 1 — the sections on power and the “faces of power.”

Think about this: who has power over your daily life that you have *never once watched them exercise*?

See you Thursday

See you Thursday

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Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011 · Submissions: Blackboard

Reading for next time is on the module page and Blackboard.